T3

[Tales Through Things]

A living material biography of a family

Tales Through Things

T³ is a domestic ritual device that shapes family stories through the perspective of everyday objects.

Inspired by the Japanese concept of Tsukumogami – spirits that awaken in objects after long years of use – T3 gives everyday things a voice. It positions them as narrators: witnesses to the moments, gestures, and relationships that shaped family life.

Because we often preserve objects to remember the stories they carry, T3 proposes another approach: instead of keeping the objects themselves, it generates symbolic ones that intentionally carry these memories forward.

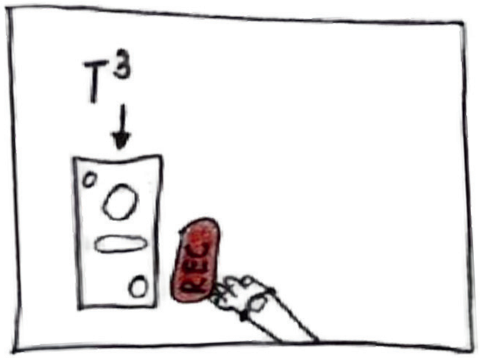
Each generated object becomes the narrator of a short tale told from its own perspective.

This tale is printed on a small paper ticket — the only place where the story exists — turning the ticket into a trace of the object's emotional rather than commercial value.

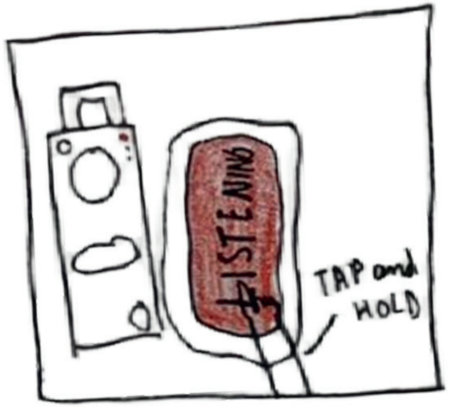
Over time, these objects form a catalogue of family narratives transmitted across generations.

A living material biography of a family.

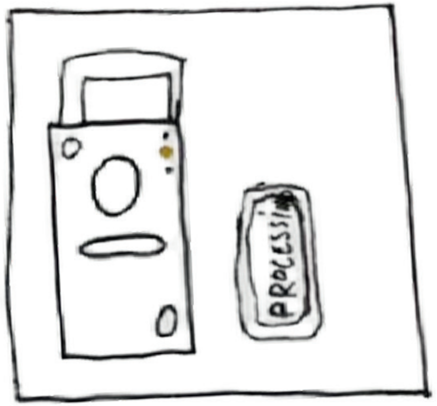
User Journey



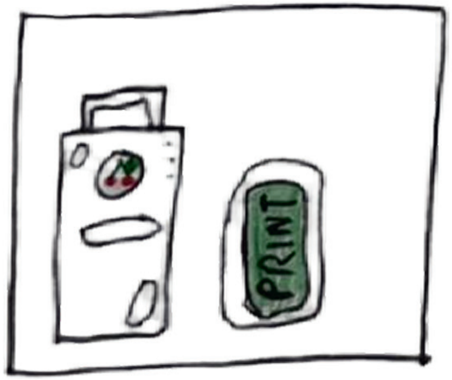
Initiation
Something just happened.
A moment worth keeping.
The user approaches the T3 and picks up the recorder placed beside it.



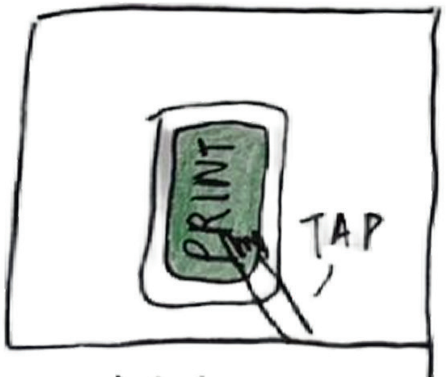
Story Recording
User tell a story. The red light shows that their words are being heard.
The user holds the button to record. Releasing stops it. Red LED indicates recording.



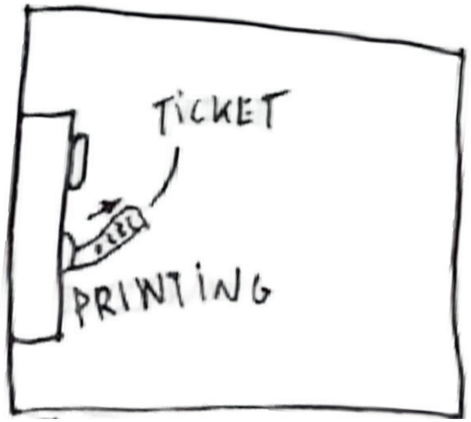
Processing
Somewhere inside, the story is being understood and transformed.
The system generates a 3D object, a first-person tale, and a title. Yellow LED blinks.



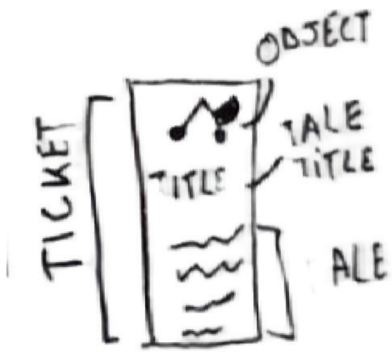
Object Reveal
Unexpected yet familiar. Their words are translated into form.
The 3D object gradually appears on the screen through the transparent display window.



Printed Output
What was intangible becomes physical. Memory now exists.
User presses Print; ticket shows object image, title, and story.

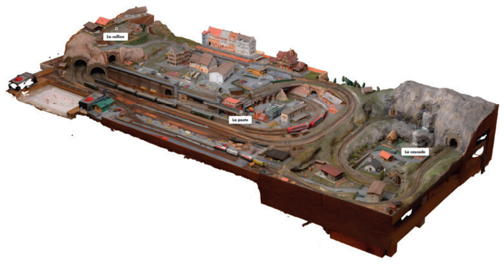


Completion
The memory now exists beyond the user, ready to be preserved.
The user receives the printed ticket as a tangible memento of their story.



Context research

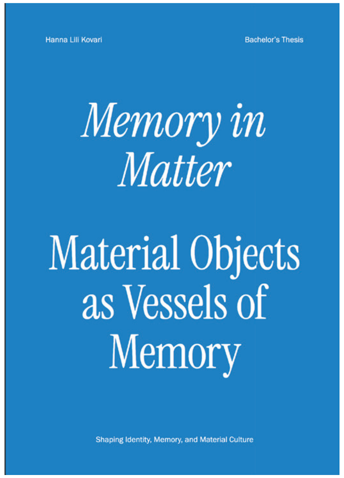
Model Making [Nicolas Grosfort, 2022]
Explored preserving a handcrafted train model in 3D after its physical destruction, highlighting how objects can carry personal and familial memories.



Peper Ghost [John Henry Pepper, 1948]
Optical illusion technique that projects images onto an angled transparent surface, creating the impression of three-dimensional objects floating in space.

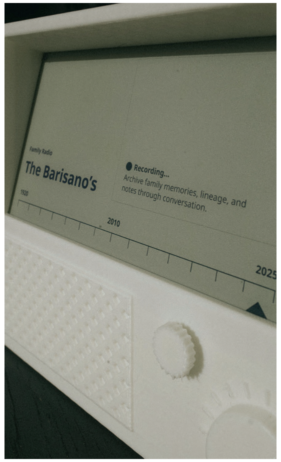
Synthetic Spirits [Neil Mendoza, 2026]
Explores the Tsukumogami of historical Japanese objects, using technology to give objects a simulated «soul» that emerges over time (after 100y).

Memory in Matter [Hanna Lily Covari, 2025]
Investigates our intimate relationship with objects, highlighting their biographies and social lives, and inspiring the idea of objects as temporal capsules that preserve and connect past experiences.



Archives [oio Studio, 2023]
Presents «Curious», an interface connected to a microphone, capable of navigating and narrating a body of knowledge (MUDAC archives).

Memory in Matter [Garden 3D, 2026]
Explores using local LLMs to manage family memories, leveraging everyday objects, like a radio, as contextual anchors to navigate the family's historical and nostalgic heritage.



Magnetic Fragment [Elena Biazi, 2025]
Explores interactive navigation of fragmented family memories, presenting video snippets in a 3D interface that allows non-linear exploration of personal histories.

String Telephone
A simple device using two connected cups or cans to transmit sound via vibrations, highlighting playful and tangible ways to communicate across space.

Perchoirs pour humains [Daily tous les jours, SD]
A forest listening path that activates hidden bird symphonies through human interaction, using life-sized perches to engage the body and invite active, embodied listening.

Picturephone [Bell Systems, 1960]
Prototype of a video telephone that allowed users to see the person they were speaking to during a call.

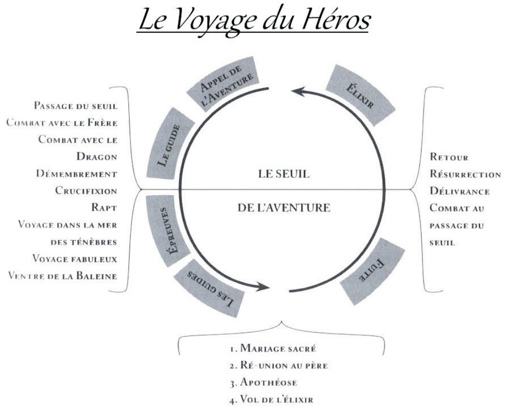
PICTORIAL NEWS OF THE DAY

Soon You'll Get Wrong Face With Wrong Number

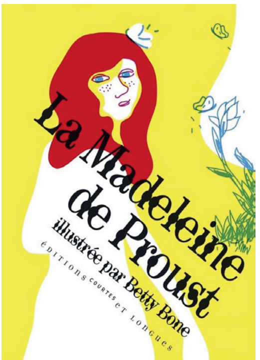
A telephone that transmits pictures along with sound has taken a big step towards commercial feasibility according to an announcement by Bell Telephone Laboratories. Here is Bell's W.E. Kock demonstrating how one experimental model of a "picture-phone" would be used. The picture is 2 x 3 inches. Protruding above is the camera lens. Knobs are for turning on the set and defining the picture.

NEWS FLASH - British Set Terms In Cyprus Revolt - For details, consult your local paper

Le Voyage du Héros [Joseph Cambell]
A 12-step narrative model that describes the universal initiatory journey of a hero, often used in literature and film.



La Madelaine de Proust [Marcel Proust, 1909]
An expression referring to a sensory trigger (taste, smell, sound) that suddenly and involuntarily brings back happy childhood memories, taken from Marcel Proust book.



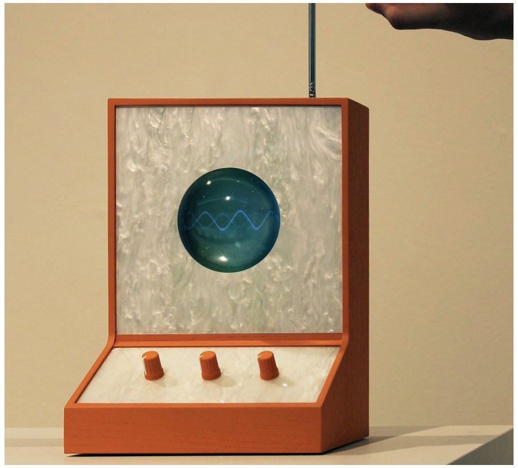
Tsukumogami
Tsukumogami are Japanese objects or artifacts that, after reaching 100 years of age, come to life and become .

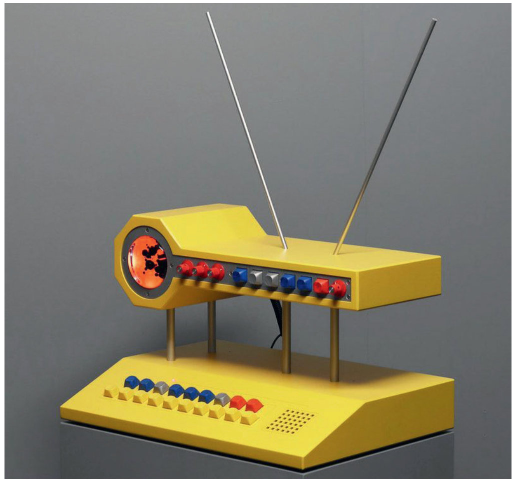
Early memory tickets [Paulius Katkevicius (Kostas father), 2015]
Postcards are small narrative artefacts that capture fragments of everyday life and memorable trips. They act as emotional traces of precious moments that can be kept, revisited, and passed across generations.

The Interface - Key visuals

Prototype
The device is a box made from orange and black MDF.
All parts were cut using CNC and laser-cutting machines, then assembled by hand.

The Interface - Key visuals





Inspirations
Inspired by retro hi-fi devices and Japanese audio branding, the design embraces a playful character and a minimal, user-friendly interface with only a few buttons.

User Tests

Memories First, Specs Later

Technical descriptions (size/weight) were boring and difficult for users. By shifting the flow to start with personal stories, users became naturally more expressive, which provided much richer and more accurate physical details for the AI.

User Control over AI Agency

To prevent the AI from «eavesdropping» on background noise or interrupting the user, we implemented a physical REC button. This «Push-to-Talk» interaction gives the user total control over when they are being heard, solving the friction of unintended AI interruptions.

Visualizing the Journey

To fight «conversation fatigue» and the feeling of an «infinite» dialogue, we added a 3-step progress bar. This, combined with LED status indicators, gives the user a clear roadmap and a sense of progress during the archiving process.

From Guided Conversation to User Autonomy

We moved from a guided AI conversation to letting users freely tell their story. The AI adapts to whatever is shared, simplifying the interaction and empowering the user.

Material list

Electronics

iPad Mini (6th generation)
Raspberry Pi 5 (maximum configuration)
Raspberry Pi 5 power supply
Adafruit Mini Thermal Printer
3 LEDs (Red, Yellow, Green)
Rotary encoder (rotary button)
Push buttons (Record, Print, Reset)
USB lavalier microphone

Cables & Connectivity

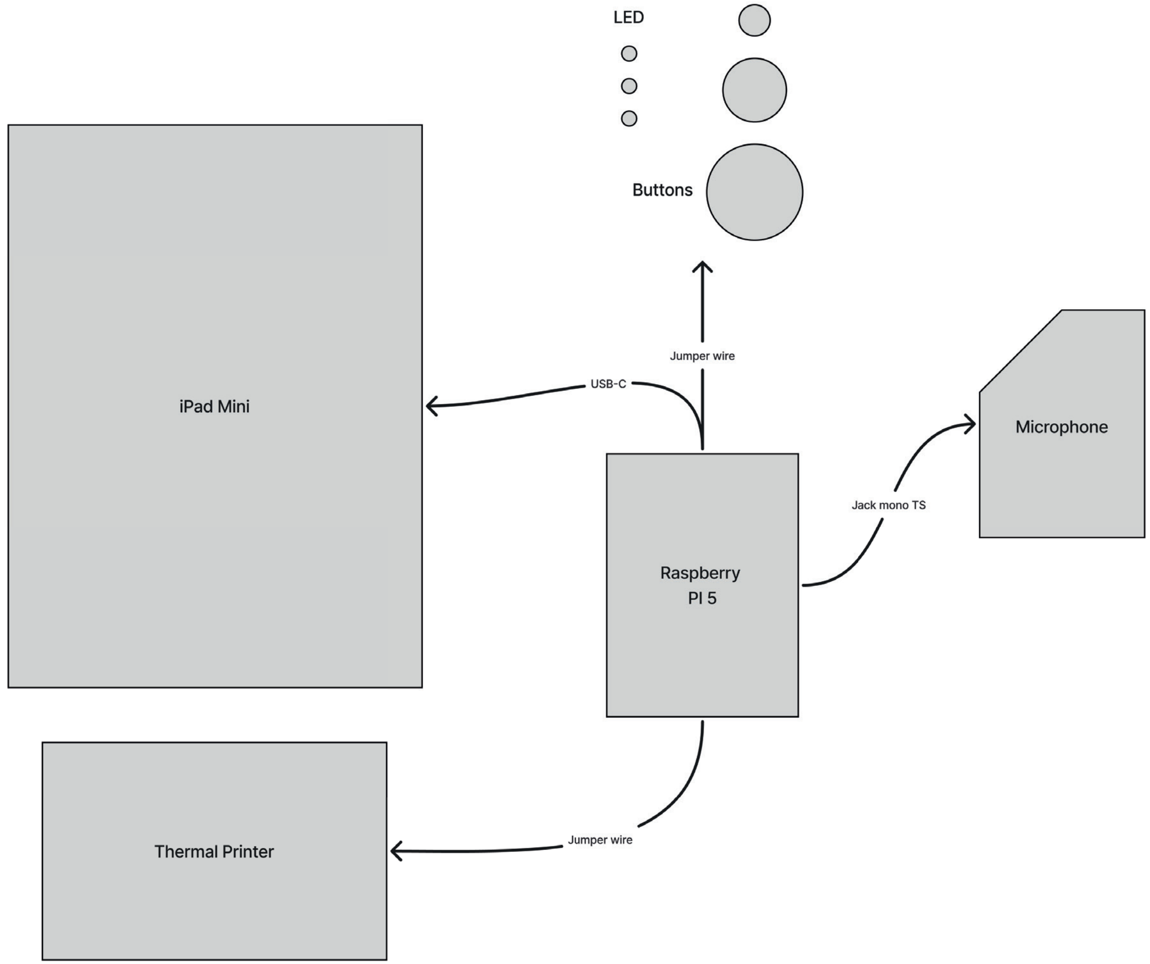
Jumper wires
USB-C cable
USB-C to USB adapter
Female USB-C connector
6.3 mm female jack connector

Materials

Transparent plexiglass (PET) – Ø141 mm, 3 mm thickness
Orange MDF – 8 mm thickness
Thermal ticket paper roll

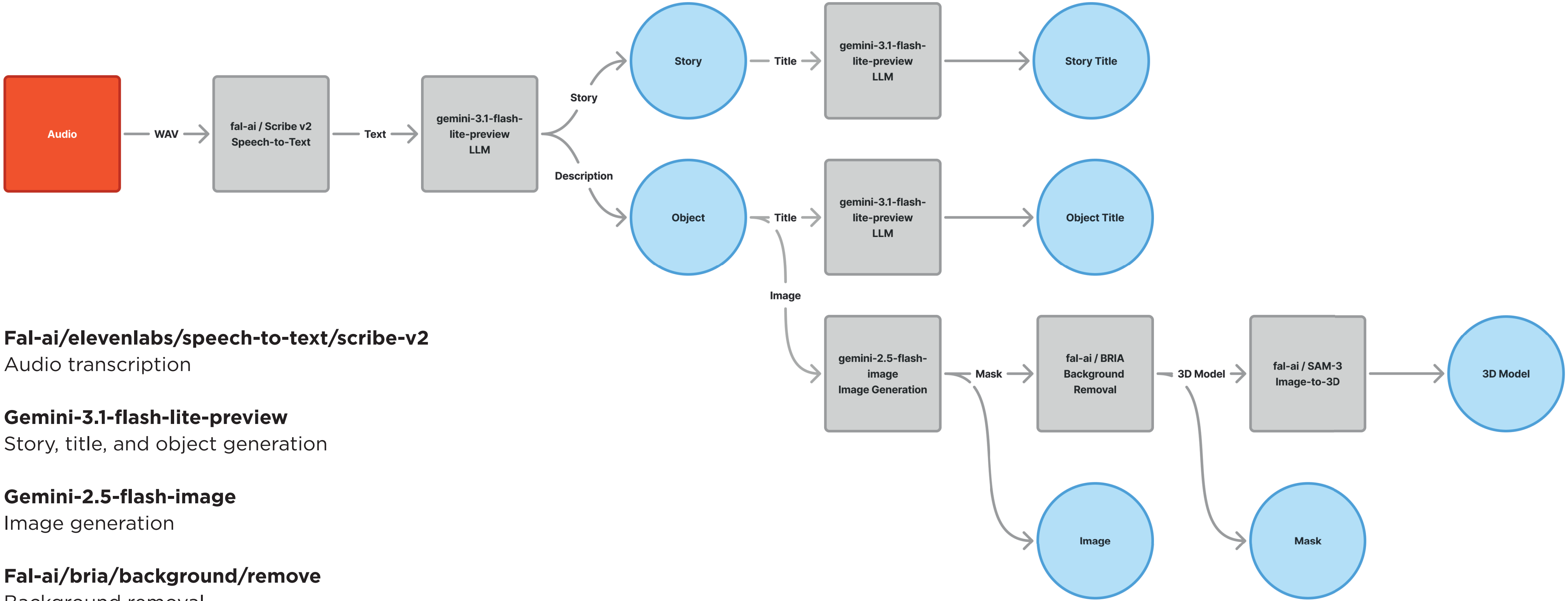
Hardware

Screws – Ø6 mm
3D printed buttons
3D printed rotary knob



[technical diagram of components]

AI models & API



Fal-ai/elevenlabs/speech-to-text/scribe-v2
Audio transcription

Gemini-3.1-flash-lite-preview
Story, title, and object generation

Gemini-2.5-flash-image
Image generation

Fal-ai/bria/background/remove
Background removal

Fal-ai/sam-3/3d-objects
3D model generation

[AI workflow]

What’s next ?

Must

Implement onboarding at initial state
- Display a random phrase inviting the user to share a memory, based on family context
- Example: Tell me a story about [random-list-word]
- random-list-word: your family, your day, your aunt, your room, ...

Secure components in the case
- iPad mini: double-sided screws
- Raspberry Pi: wood screws
- Thermal printer: wood screws
- Fix cables and plugs
- Assemble the box (screw the panel)

Finalize button design
- 3D print

Facilitate ticket handling
- Widen the slot
- Add a cut zone
- Create an opening to change the paper roll

Implement microphone case
- Assemble the case
- Integrate microphone component
- Integrate button component
- Implement interactions with API

Add ventilation holes in the case
- Overheating observed during demo
- Fan may be necessar

Should

Preserve states on the server (allow retrieval when reconnecting)

Run AI models locally
- Use a separate server
- Expose an API
- Implement object library
- Display object/story titles on the screen
- Change displayed object with rotary potentiometer
- Reset state after 60 seconds of inactivity

Implement RESET functionality
- Stop API pipeline
- Reset state

Could

Produce a new box

Sand the handle and edges of the case